

World War II in the Pacific

The war between Japan and the United States and its allies, often called the Pacific War, was one of the most intense conflicts of World War II. Fighting spread across a large area from Myanmar (Burma) in the west, across Southeast Asia, and out to the Pacific Ocean to the east. This war in the Pacific saw major sea battles, as well as land campaigns in Myanmar, New Guinea, and the Philippines.

In the 1870s, Japan began building an empire in East Asia, and by 1920 had taken control of Taiwan, Korea, and many Pacific islands. It seized Manchuria in 1931 and invaded the rest of China in 1937 (see pp.176–177).

The US and its allies wanted to protect their colonies in the region, so to stop Japan's expansion into Asia, the US restricted trade with the country. Japan seized French Indochina (modern-day Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia), which resulted in further restrictions. As tensions increased, Japan attacked Pearl Harbor—a US naval and air base in Hawaii—in December 1941. This immediately brought the US into World War II.

Japan quickly conquered European colonies in Asia. It seemed impossible to halt the Japanese advance until the Allies discovered their secret plans in 1942. After two major sea battles, the Allies began taking control of the Pacific and advanced on Japan island by island. In 1945, the US dropped two atomic bombs on Japan, forcing it to surrender and ending World War II.

BOMBING PEARL HARBOR ►

The attack on Pearl Harbor took the Americans by complete surprise. In two bombing missions on the morning of December 7, 1941, Japanese aircraft sank or damaged around 18 US warships, destroyed almost 200 planes, and killed more than 2,400 Americans.



FACT

As Japan began to lose the war, suicide pilots known as *kamikaze* crash-dived their planes into US ships to blow them up. More than 2,500 lost their lives in a desperate attempt to avoid defeat and dishonor.



▲ INVADING ASIA AND THE PACIFIC

After their attack on Pearl Harbor, the Japanese launched a series of quick, highly successful invasions of colonies held by the US, Britain, and the Netherlands in the region. Up to 136,000 British troops surrendered to the Japanese in Singapore, then a British colony, in February 1942.